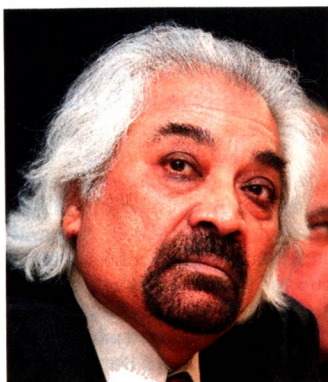




MANMOHAN SINGH
WITH HRD MINISTER
ARJUN SINGH



“ The excess land in the proposed varsities can be a subsequent income generation source. Exceptions must be made in tax laws to encourage large endowments. ”

SAM PITRODA, *Chairman, NKC*

Photo: Anshu Datta

The grievance roster has grown meatier as the UGC and NKC take each other on

The UGC does not want corporate and industry collaborations as suggested by the NKC.

The NKC also wants to develop a mechanism to monitor the performance of teachers.

The NKC is in the favour of active private participation to which the UGC doesn't quite agree.

The UGC opposes the proposal to outsource non-teaching staff wherever possible.

universities down the drain. For the World Class Universities, it insists on freewheeling career advancement schemes amid concerns that it would minimise the productivity. “There should not be any career advancement schemes so that faculty appointments at every level are through open competition. There should be incentives for teachers who have performed well,” says Kiran Datar, former Dean of Colleges, Delhi University.

The NKC in its letter to the UGC

chairman has also suggested that the syllabi should be revised every year to keep up with the changes and current developments in various disciplines. “Departments that do not update their syllabi for two consecutive years shall be asked to provide justifications,” says the letter. Another contentious issue is that of fixing fees and granting autonomy to the proposed universities. The commission had envisaged that these universities shall have the autonomy to set student fee levels and tap other sources for

generating funds such as industry collaborations and overseas operations. The autonomy of fees and greater autonomy for each university is a strict no-no for both the ministry as well as the UGC. Prompted by incisive memos from the Prime Minister's Office, which is attuned with the views of the NKC, the ministry is planning to prepare a bill with critical minimum provisions, thereby enabling autonomy and innovation without going through a parliamentary process at a later stage. Otherwise, it will have to resort to the ordinance route, bypassing Parliament.

Others argue that it is patently absurd to declare a university world class, as government fiat won't make it so. The experts point to the King Abdullah University of Science and Technology in Saudi Arabia. It has a start-up grant of \$10 billion or Rs 50,000 crore: three-and-a-half times India's provision for 14 universities. Still, the money poured into the oil kingdom's university is no guarantee that it will steal the thunder from the West. “World Class Universities grow over time, each along its unique trajectory, impelled from within by the faculty and students and, at one remove, by the community. The government can at most provide funds and ensure congenial working conditions. It may be possible to create a world-class educational facility by throwing enough money at a greenfield campus,” says Sukanta Chaudhuri, professor, Jadavpur University.

As a first step, the ministry has decided to do away with the tag of World Class University, an idea which has won it the NKC's applause. The Act will now be termed the National Universities System Act instead of the World Class University System Act. “We can't name a child ‘genius’, who is at risk of growing up clueless,” says a ministry official. Here's hoping the message gets sharper in eternal stakeholder meetings over paneer pakoras at Shastri Bhavan. ■